Given that Ashoka succeeded to the throne in a manner that was never planned or anticipated by his father, and in bloody circumstances, his consecration could not but have left him acutely aware of the problems that would likely beset his monarchy. Ensuring the loyalty of administrators would in such circumstances have been imperative. It is, then, a fair guess that the *Ashokavadana* embroidered an elaborate story around the motif of loyalty to the king, of punishment by death in the face of disobedience or vindictiveness against him. It resonated completely with what was known about the early exigencies of his rule.

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If the Northern Buddhist tradition produced an exaggerated portrait of a fiercely cruel Ashoka in the years after his assumption of kingship, it was an entirely different image, that of a restlessly enquiring emperor, which was woven into the tale that the Sri Lankan texts told about his early reign. The purpose of their telling was to highlight the notion that Ashoka's quest for a worthy spiritual preceptor was what led him to Buddhism, not because he had any inherent predilection for the faith. He might, after all, have chosen the other newly risen faith, Jainism, which was so fiercely opposed to harming all forms of life that its tenets in favour of non-violence were fanatic. A king in search of a faith advocating compassion could well, in normal circumstances, have looked more favourably upon the worldview of Mahavira than on that of the Buddha. To account for Ashoka's preference for Buddhism over every other competing form of religious compassion thus seemed to require the attractions of a wise man, someone sage-like whose charisma swayed the emperor in the direction he chose. So we learn that the recently consecrated king 'unceasingly . . . searched after virtuous, clever men', and for such men he was willing to give up his kingdom—all that he had inherited and conquered. Considering that Devi was an important part of his life and happened to be a Buddhist it is somewhat